

GIANT STRIDES

PRAMOD PUSHPAKARTIA

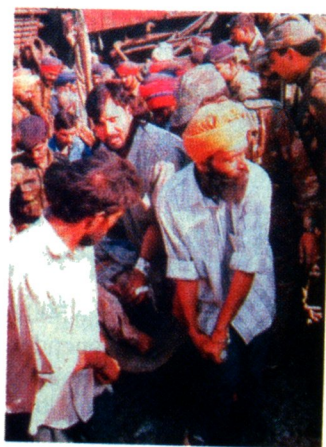
◀◀ REWIND

Five nuclear tests conducted over two days made India blast its way into the exclusive nuclear club. Codenamed Shakti, meaning strength, the nuclear tests in Pokhran on May 11 and 13 opened the floodgates for ethical debates and a wave of sanctions against the country. India's success might have been doubted by western scientists, but the country was proud of its "big bomb".



DEATH ON TRACKS

In the year's worst train accident, the Sealdah Express and the Frontier Mail collided on November 26, killing 220 and injuring 300. Cruising at 100 kmph, the drivers of the Amritsar-bound Frontier Mail were oblivious to the fact that nine bogies of the train had got detached. A minute later, the Sealdah Express rammed into three of the detached bogies that had overturned on the adjacent track. The accident was so terrible that it took the authorities over 12 hours to extricate the dead bodies.



FREE ENTRY

The Government opened up the economy further by scrapping import curbs on 340 items such as consumer products and liberalised all major export promotion schemes.

FIRST CUT

• In a first, the World Bank singled out Andhra Pradesh, led by Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, for a loan of Rs 2,200 crore for the state alone.

• Sonia Gandhi got elected as Congress president for the first time, becoming the fifth member of the Nehru-Gandhi family to occupy the post, following Sitaram Kesri's resignation after the party's defeat.

◀◀ DID YOU KNOW

Admiral Bhagwat was sacked for "defiance of civilian authority". The government's decision to remove the controversial naval chief was seen as a transgression of civilian authority in the domain of defence.